

Therefore, we continue to bring you our quarterly update.

E-tailers wooing customers in the metaverse

All major e-commerce brands have been experimenting with the metaverse in the past few months. As part of its Great Indian Festival, Amazon brought its Metaworld experience to a few Indian cities, including Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Kanpur, and Nagpur. This was an expo kind of setup, replete with actual physical events like concerts and games.

The highlight, however, was the kiosks that visitors could use to experience the virtual Metaworld. Here their *avatars* could browse through their favourite Amazon categories, as well as play against each other to win offers and deals.

In October, Flipkart also trialed its Flipverse on the Polygon platform. Several well-known brands, including Puma and Noise, participated in the week-long pilot run. Touted to be the company's entry into Web3, and as the beginning of E-commerce 2.0, Flipverse gives users an AAA gaming environment (a high-profile, high-budget, high-performance gaming experience, informally expanded as a lot of money, a lot of resources, and a lot of time) where their digital avatars can discover products, unlock special offers, and purchase unique collectibles.

The company aims to enter the next level of consumer engagement and retention through Flipverse by creating a bi-directional bond between users and their favourite brands. Flipverse apparently features a very photorealistic visual space, and also lets users build photorealistic digital avatars from selfies.

According to a Polygon blog, "The crown jewel in the Flipverse is eDAO's The Strand, a free collectible that opens access to intellectual properties (IPs), brands, and culture. The Strand gives users a tangible

connection to their beloved icons, artists, and brands. It is a promise that you will always be a citizen of the culture multiverse. Over 75,000 have been activated to date."

In September, Walmart launched Walmart Land and Walmart's Universe of Play on the popular metaverse platform Roblox. Basically, digital avatars can move through the space and collect coins strewn around, or play games to earn them and spend them at a virtual store to buy virtual merchandise—termed as 'verch'—for their digital avatars. Well, sounds like just another virtual reality game (creating the fear of missing out).

Speaking at the Yahoo Finance All Markets Summit in October this year, Suresh Kumar, the global CTO of Walmart, remarked that the way customers are getting inspired and are discovering products is changing. Hence, in the future, live broadcasting on the metaverse and marketing through social media platforms would be effective ways to reach a large segment of consumers.

He also predicted that Bitcoin might play a significant role in that environment's payment system, adding that both physical and virtual goods would be purchased using crypto. Some of Walmart's patent applications indicate that the company is working on creating digital currency, tokens, and non-fungible tokens (NFTs) for the metaverse.

Automakers and others too

Not just e-tailers, but even offline brands are dipping their feet in the metaverse. We caught up with the long list of automakers launching models on the metaverse in September's metaverse round-up. This included names like Mahindra, Maruti Suzuki, MG Motor, and Hyundai.

More of them joined this quarter. TVS Motor Company, a leading two-wheeler manufacturer headquartered in Chennai, launched the TVS



Potential buyer exploring EVs on metaverse dealership (Courtesy: 1Verse)

Raider with SmartXconnect technology on their metaverse platform, TVS Motoverse. According to the company, this is the first motorcycle to be launched on the metaverse.

In October, 1Verse and Tyremarket.com launched the world's first fully-integrated metaverse based dealership to sell two- and three-wheel electric vehicles (EVs) throughout India. They have adopted a fusion model, which allows users to shop through local metaverse kiosks (basically local dealers equipped with VR gear), or through their own computers or mobile phones. Through a newly-formed subsidiary, Tyremarket.com provides sales expertise, local EV distribution, technology enhancements, and access to tens of millions of existing customers in India.

"1Verse features the capability to create metaverse EV storefronts, where brick and mortar sales infrastructure is limited. Instead of traveling 50 miles or more to an EV dealership, people will be able to access a physical location right near them, where they can look at, customise and even test drive the EV that they want to purchase," says Prashanth Joshua, Co-founder and CEO of 1Verse.

Democratising the metaverse

Recently, Reliance Industries Limited (RIL) posted the proceedings of its